

DROWNING THE RUMOUR
Annamayya SP Dheeraj Kunubilli addressing the media, Feb. 18

man rights activists, with the citizenry attracted to the idea of 'natural justice' being served.

Take Kulavardhan, 30, the latest to meet a watery grave. Reportedly a drug and alcohol addict with a criminal record, he was accused of sexually assaulting and murdering a seven-year-old girl from his neighbourhood, near Madanapalle. The girl went missing on February 16 while playing near her house. After a search by family and locals, joined in by police, she was found dead the next day, her body stuffed into a water drum in Kulavardhan's house.

CALLS FOR INSTANT JUSTICE

The sight of her assaulted body sparked public outrage, and locals, joined by political representatives, blocked a highway for hours, demanding that the accused be handed over to them or be hanged in public. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Annamayya district SP Dheeraj Kunubilli said they caught Kulavardhan, but he escaped as a small posse of cops were busy pacifying a furious mob that was trying to assault the accused.

At any rate, Kulavardhan was found drowned in a lake near Angallu, about 10 km away, the next morning. No one is mourning his end, even if its stated nature is doubted. "I don't think a fellow of such criminal nature ends his life out of remorse. Maybe he got afraid. Maybe he was afraid or was overwhelmed by repentance and ended his life," says the area DSP, Venkateshwara Rao.

Takeaways

- **At least three accused in rape/murder cases in AP have been found 'drowned'**
- **'Instant justice,' says the public. 'Cooked-up stories,' say human rights activists**

it's instant justice by you know who," says Naresh B., a Madanapalle local. "Whatever the reason, we are satisfied such an animal is no more amidst us."

In October 2025, the body of Narayana Rao, 62, accused in an attempt to sexually assault a minor girl at a residential school at Tuni in Kakinada district, was found dead in a lake. Rao was taken into police custody but reportedly escaped after seeking to relieve himself. If the patterns in the story escape no one, perhaps it's because they are not meant to.

In June 2025, one Md Rahmatullah, 26, accused of raping and murdering a three-year-old Dalit girl at Mylavaram in Kadapa district, went fugitive. After about 10 days, he was found—yes—drowned in a reservoir nearby. "We could not formally arrest him. He escaped from our vehicle amid the commotion. DNA investigations confirmed him as the offender. Maybe

'SAFER' ALTERNATIVE

It's all "cooked-up stories", says Yedida Rajesh, general secretary, AP chapter of Human Rights Forum, adding: "The accounts are too dramatic. True, the public and political pressure can be immense. Also, legal processes are time-consuming and tiring." He points out that the police seem to have arrived at a "safer" alternative. "Earlier, it used to be encounter killings. But the Telangana cops in the Disha case faced intense scrutiny and an inquiry, though their act was hailed as heroic by the public."

He concedes the pace of Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) trials is frustratingly slow, increasing the despair for victim families. "There are about 5,900 pending POCSO cases in AP. The act says cases have to be concluded in a year, but many have been dragging on for years, some from 2021." P.V. Krishnamachary, advocate for the families of the four slain in the Disha case, says in some cases the police are driven to bypass the system due to "public anger and negative publicity. Such killings help them rebuild a positive image quickly".

Asked about the incidents, Koya Praveen, DIG Kurnool Range, under which the Kadapa and Annamayya districts fall, says the police had absolutely no role in the deaths. "We are there to uphold the law. When there's ample evidence, why resort to instant justice? We are law-enforcers, not film heroes," Koya says. However, the ruling Telugu Desam Party (TDP) is seeking credit for the endings. In a post on X after Kulavardhan's death, the party's official handle shared a montage of pictures and a poster saying, 'Chandrababu punishes those who mess with girls.' The words below had the caveat: that the accused committed suicide driven by this fear. ■